

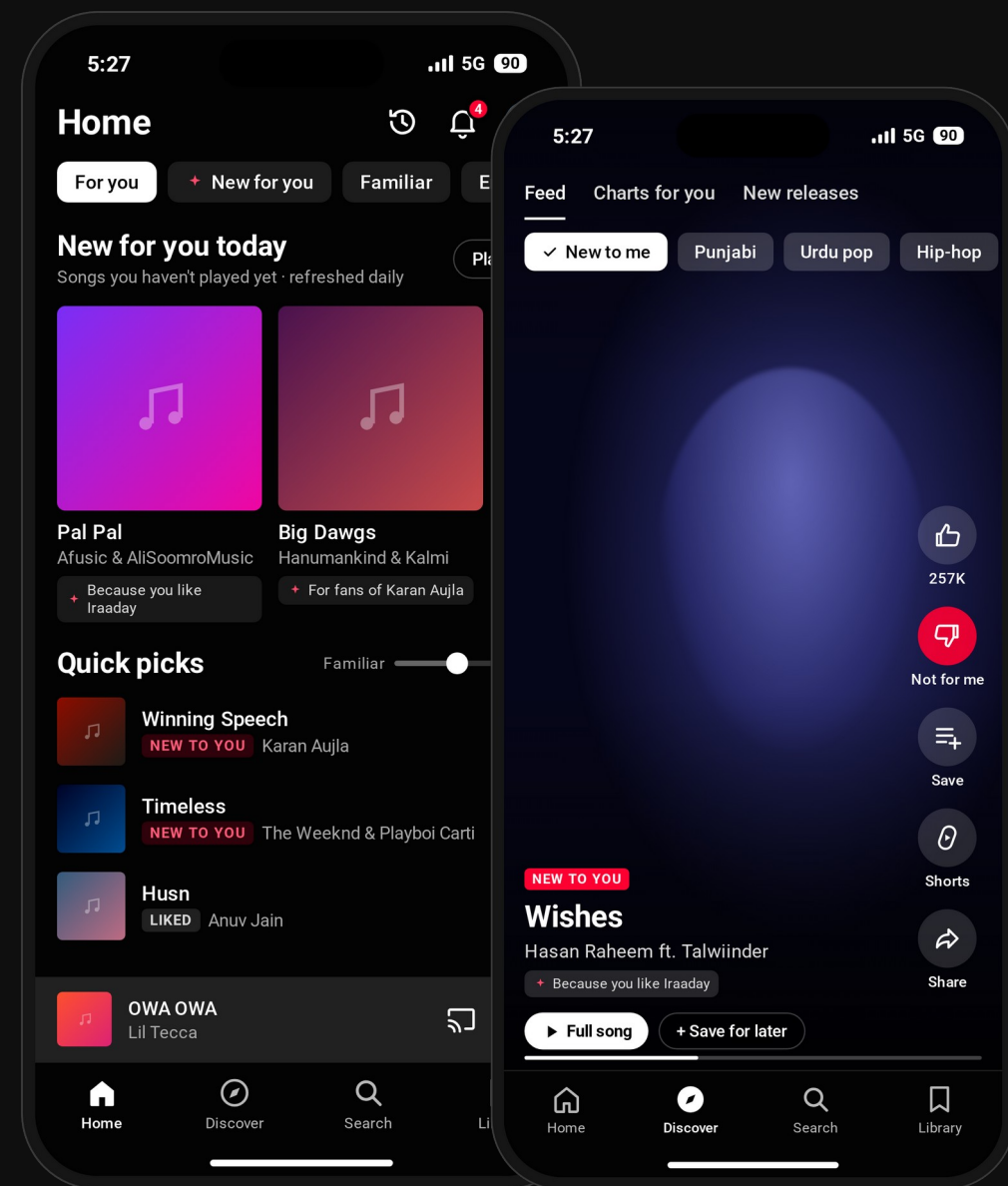
YouTube Music

From replay machine to discovery engine

A teardown of the Premium experience in India: a audit, root-cause diagnosis, prioritised bets, concept mocks, and the metrics and experiments to prove them.

Ashutosh Singh
2026

Independent case study; not affiliated with or endorsed by Google or YouTube. Screens captured on the iOS app with a Premium account. Concept mocks use illustrative data.



YouTube Music wins the replay but leaks discovery. Five bets rebuild the “find new music I’ll love” loop

SITUATION

125M

YouTube Music + Premium subscribers globally, including trials (Mar 2025). Q1 2026 was the largest quarterly non-trial add to date.

8%

of India’s 178M music streamers pay (2025). YouTube (32%) and Spotify (31%) are neck and neck on 3-month usage.

COMPLICATION

Replay-first Home

Speed dial, Quick picks and “From your library” fill the first screens with music I already play. The same songs repeat across modules.

Discovery has no tab

Since Jun 2026, Charts and New releases sit in Search’s empty state. Samples, an unfilterable video feed, is the only discovery tab.

No steering

Feedback works one song at a time. Paying users publicly complain about AI-generated tracks in recommendations.

RESOLUTION: 5 BETS

- 1 Fresh Home**
New-to-me row, dedupe, Familiar ↔ Fresh dial
- 2 Discover hub**
Feed + Charts for you + New releases in one tab
- 3 Steering controls**
Block artist, fewer like this, less AI music
- 4 One-tap History**
Clock icon on Home, “heard it in Samples” labels
- 5 UI hygiene sprint**
Six small defects fixed in one sprint

North star: Weekly New-Favourite Listeners

YouTube Music has scale and momentum, and has reshuffled where discovery lives three times in three years

125M

Music + Premium subscribers globally, incl. trials (Mar 2025)

₹119

per month for YouTube Music Premium in India; ₹149 for YouTube Premium

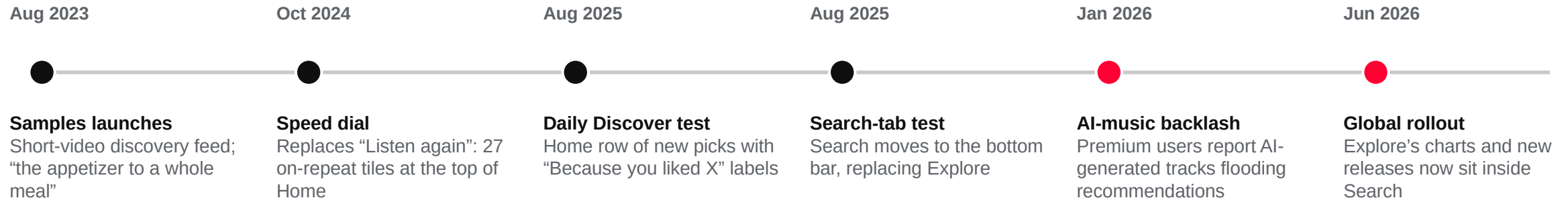
256 kbps

Maximum streaming quality (AAC/Opus). No lossless tier

4 tabs

Home · Samples · Search · Library since the June 2026 redesign

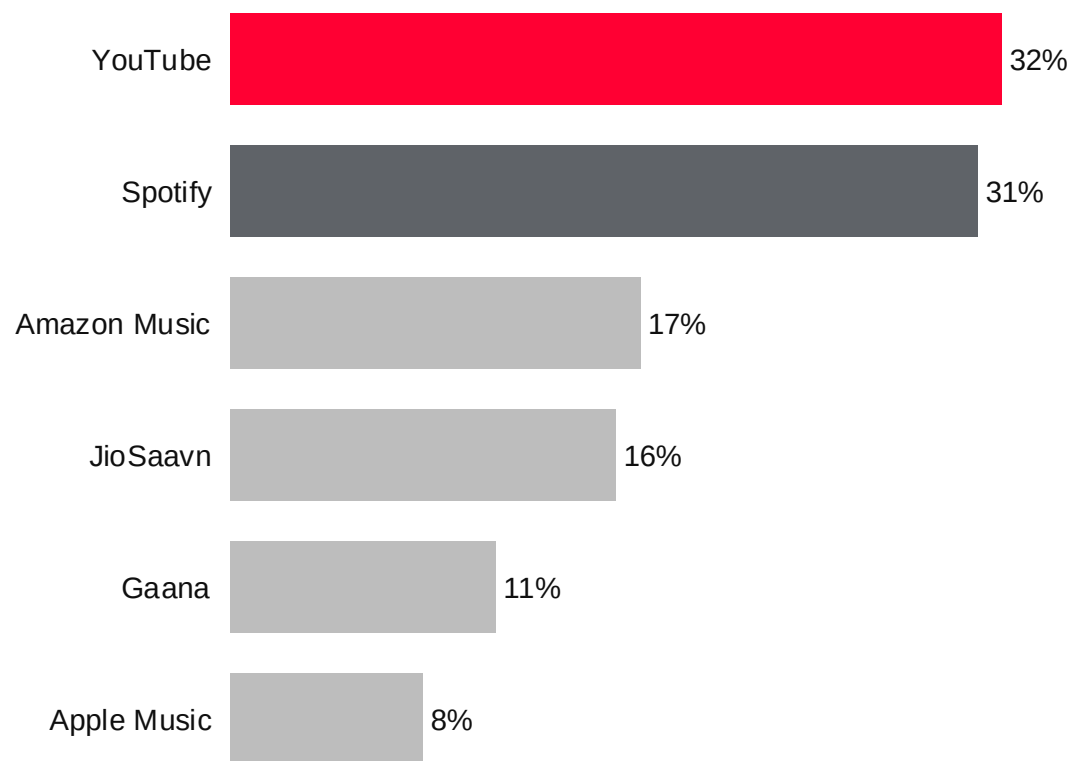
HOW DISCOVERY HAS MOVED AROUND THE APP



SO WHAT YouTube itself is still searching for where discovery belongs. That makes it a live, high-leverage problem, not a nitpick.

India is the growth prize: 178M streamers, only 8% paying, and the top two services are neck and neck

Used for music in the last 3 months (% of smartphone users, India, 2026)



Multi-homing is common: these add up to more than 100%.

14.4M

paid music subscriptions in India, 2025 (+~4M, 37% YoY)

28–30M

paid subscriptions forecast by 2028, roughly double

Monthly price, India (individual plans)

Plan	₹/month	Lossless
YouTube Music Premium	119	No (256 kbps)
YouTube Premium (incl. ad-free YouTube)	149	No (256 kbps)
Spotify Premium Standard	139	No
Spotify Premium Platinum	299	Yes

SO WHAT With users on several apps and prices within ₹30 of each other, discovery quality is the switching lever, not price.

Approach: a 7-screen heuristic audit, backed by public user evidence and competitor benchmarks

01

Capture

7 screens from my own Premium account on iOS (Home ×4, Search, Samples, Library), 29 Sep 2026. Profile photos blurred.



02

Audit

Nielsen's 10 heuristics, tap counts for core jobs, and a Familiar vs New-to-me tag for every Home module.



03

Back it up

Press coverage of Reddit and community threads, YouTube Help Center docs, Spotify Research, NN/g studies, India market reports.



04

Prioritise & design

Issue tree to root causes, RICE scoring, concept mocks, a north-star metric and an experiment plan.

HOW TO READ THE EVIDENCE IN THIS DECK

OBSERVED

Seen directly in my screenshots. Strong for “what”, silent on “how many users”.

REPORTED

From a named public source, cited on the slide. Reddit threads are cited through the articles that quoted them.

HYPOTHESIS

My PM judgement: RICE inputs, personas, targets. Each has a test to confirm or kill it. No YouTube internal data is assumed.

Three listener jobs. The Premium “multilingual repeat listener” is the most underserved



PRIMARY

Multilingual Repeat Listener

Premium · Punjabi, Hindi, Urdu pop, English hip-hop · builds themed playlists

JOB TO BE DONE

“When I open the app, show me new songs in my taste without making me dig.”

WHAT GETS IN THE WAY

- Home replays what I already play
- Charts are generic, not in my languages
- Scrolling Samples to find something new is tiring



GUARDRAIL

Lean-back Listener

Commutes, works out · plays mixes and radio · rarely saves or searches

JOB TO BE DONE

“Just play something good, fast.”

WHAT GETS IN THE WAY

- Well served today by Speed dial and Quick picks
- Risk: extra freshness could mean more skips
- Needs a sensible default, not more settings



SECONDARY

Crate-digger

Follows new releases and charts · heavy search · shares finds

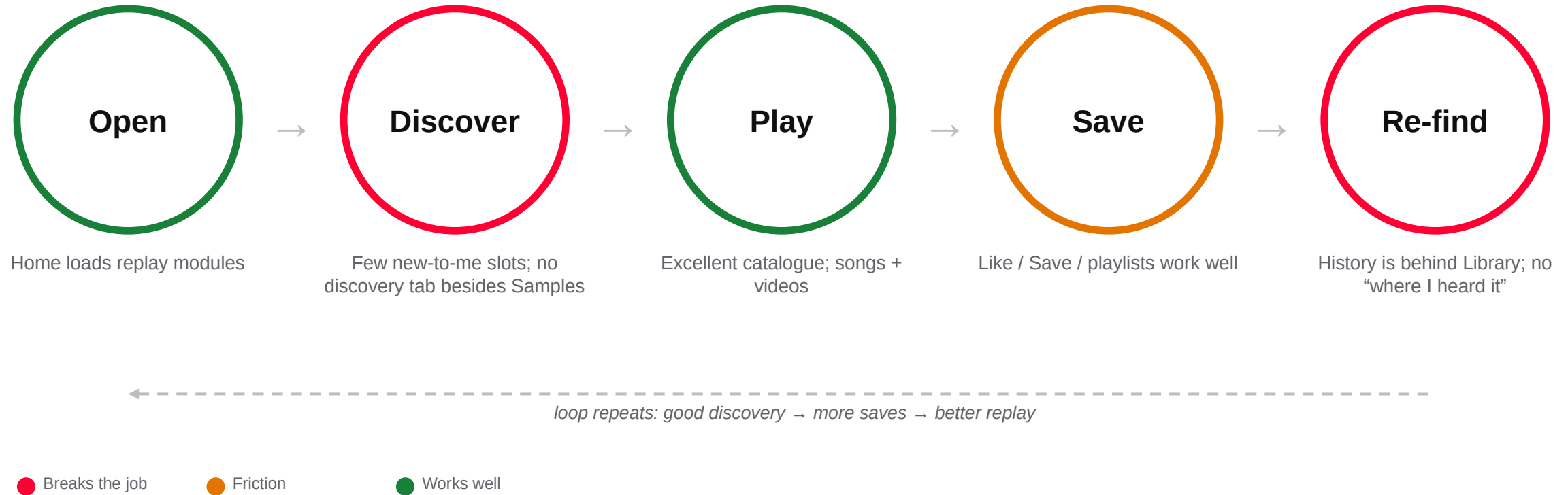
JOB TO BE DONE

“Tell me what’s new before my friends know.”

WHAT GETS IN THE WAY

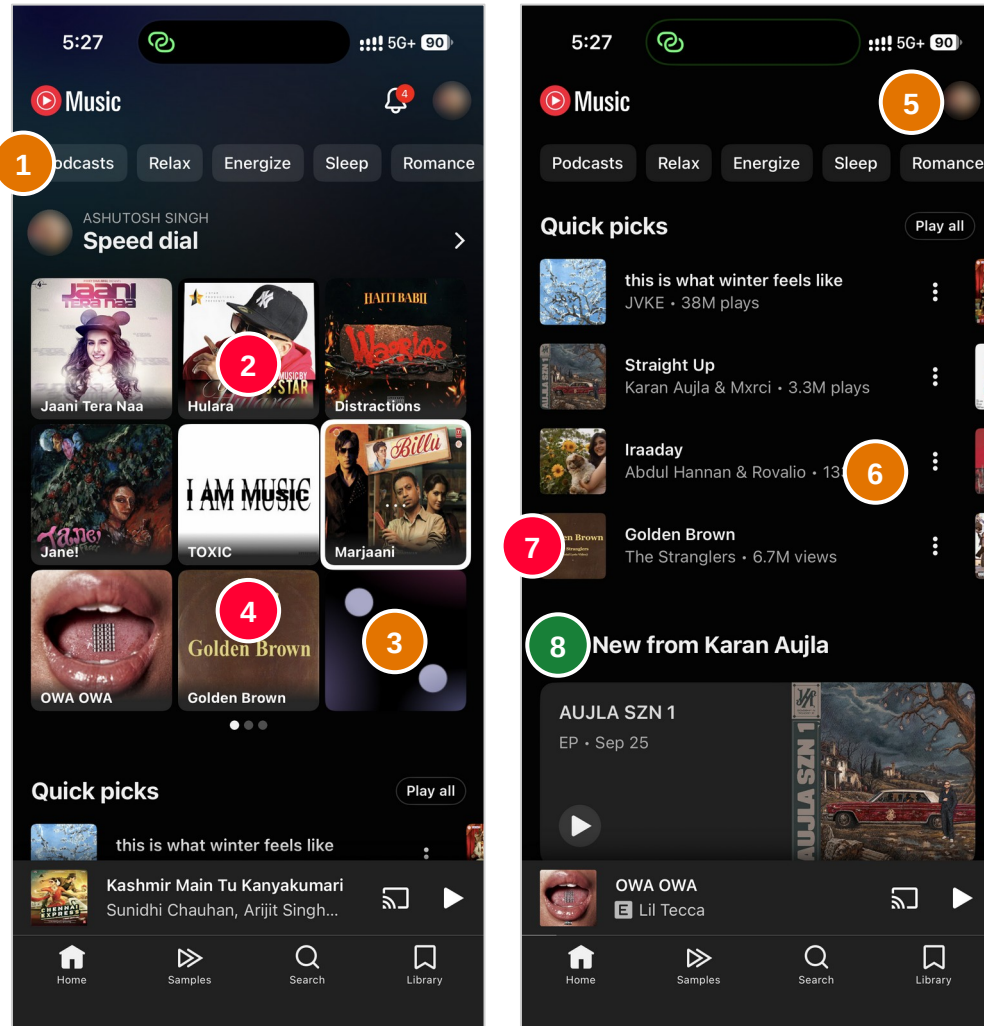
- Explore no longer has its own tab
- New releases list isn’t filtered to my artists
- Can’t tell which picks are new to me

The listening loop is strong at Play but leaks at Discover and Re-find



SO WHAT Replay feeds on discovery: every favourite today was "new to me" once. If Discover and Re-find leak, the replay library stops growing and the app gets stale.

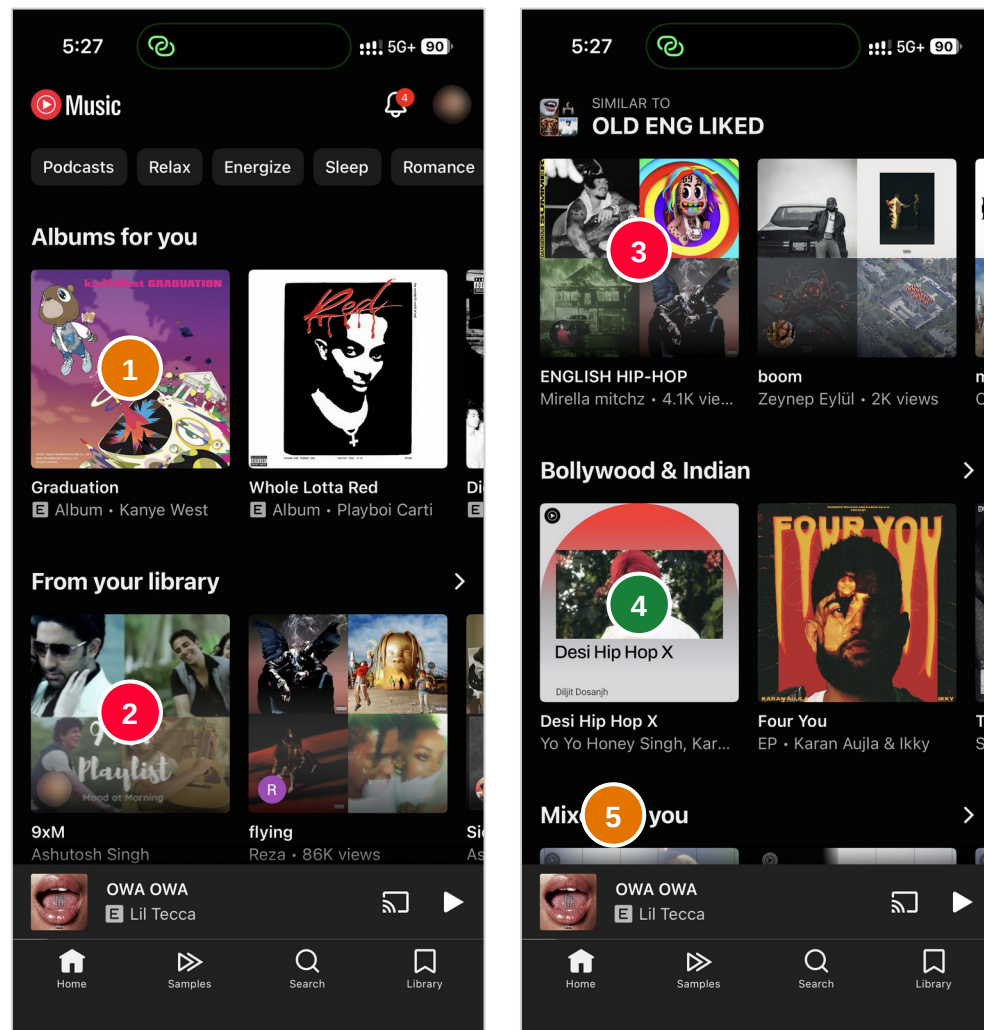
Home audit: the first two screens are almost entirely music I already play



- 1 **“Podcasts” is the first mood chip**
For a music-first subscriber, the lead filter points away from music.
- 2 **Speed dial takes the whole first screen**
9 of 27 on-repeat tiles. Zero new-to-me music before the first scroll.
- 3 **A tile with no label or artwork**
Three dots, no title. The user can’t tell what it plays.
- 4 **The same songs repeat across modules**
“Golden Brown” and “OWA OWA” each show up twice on screens 1–2.
- 5 **Top bar has only bell + profile**
No quick entry to History, which I use daily (see P5).
- 6 **Mixed “plays” vs “views”, truncated**
“133M vie...”: song and video counts mixed in one list.
- 7 **Quick picks re-serves Speed dial**
Screen 2 repeats screen 1 instead of widening it.
- 8 **“New from Karan Aujla” works**
Release from a followed artist. The pattern to scale, but it covers only one artist.

● Breaks the job ● Friction ● Works well

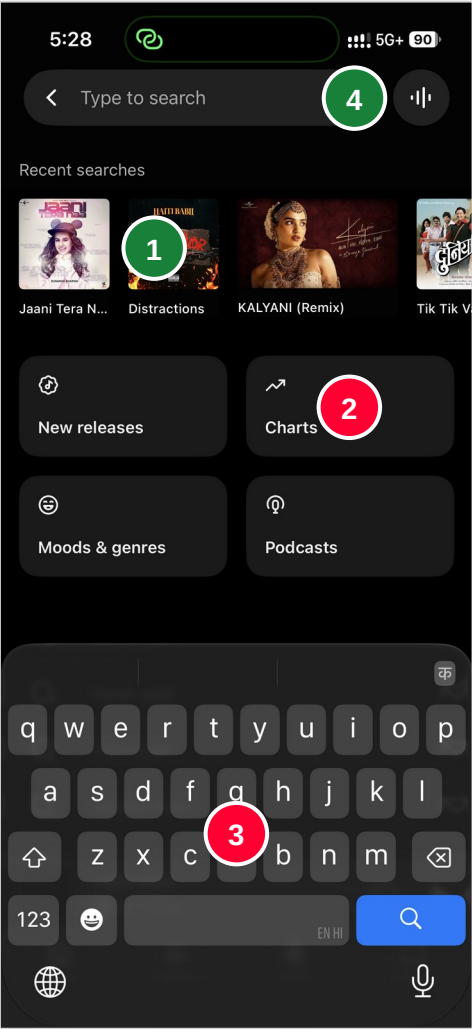
Home audit (scrolled): the rows lean on classics, my own playlists and low-signal user playlists



- 1 **“Albums for you” = the canon**
Graduation (2007) and Whole Lotta Red (2020) are safe, well-known picks, not discoveries. There’s no signal whether I’ve heard them.
- 2 **“From your library” on Home**
Re-surfaces my own playlists (9xM), which Library already shows one tap away. It uses up prime Home space.
- 3 **Low-signal user playlists recommended**
“Similar to OLD ENG LIKED” shows user-made playlists with 2K–4.1K views, with no quality or freshness cue.
- 4 **“Bollywood & Indian” is relevant**
Desi Hip Hop X and a Karan Aujla EP match my taste. Good ranking, but the row is generic in name and placement.
- 5 **“Mixed for you” sits below the fold**
The most personalised discovery row is four scrolls deep, under replay and canon rows.

SO WHAT Row order is the product’s real priority list. Today it reads: replay → canon → my stuff → discovery.

Search audit: Explore now lives in Search’s empty state. It’s generic, and hidden once the keyboard is up



- 1

Recent searches with artwork
Fast re-find of what I looked for. Keep it.
- 2

Charts / New releases / Moods are one-size-fits-all
The same four entry points for every user. Nothing is filtered to my languages or artists.
- 3

Typing and browsing share one screen
With the keyboard up (~38% of the screen), everything below the four cards is hidden, including the carousels that used to be Explore.
- 4

Voice + song-recognition entry
Good for “what’s this song?” moments.

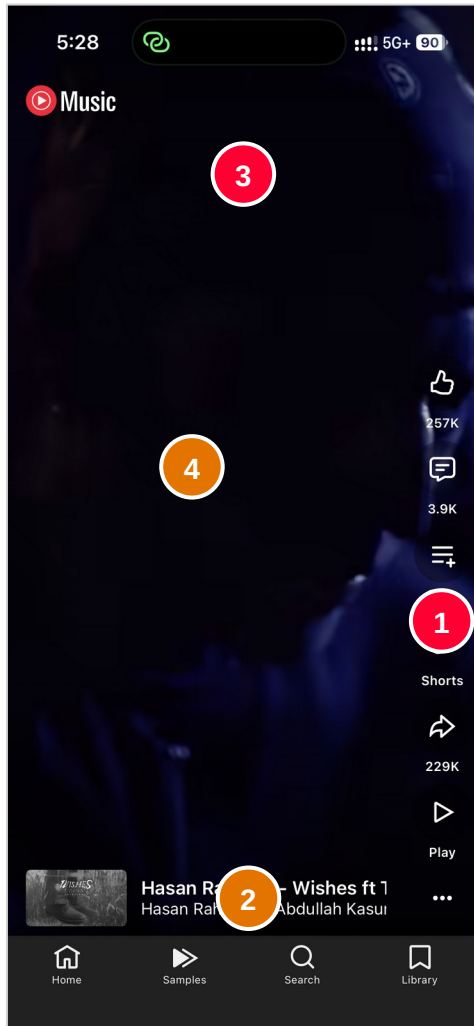
Tap count: before vs after the Jun 2026 redesign

Job	Before	Now
Start a search	1 (top-bar icon)	1 (tab)
Open Charts	2 (Explore tab)	2 (Search tab)
See Trending / New albums rows	1 + scroll	1 + scroll, no keyboard

SO WHAT Tap counts barely changed. What changed is how prominent discovery is: it went from a destination to the empty state of a utility. Nobody opens Search to browse.

My pain, in my words: *to find new music I end up scrolling Samples endlessly, because Charts are generic and hidden inside Search.*

Samples audit: a lean-back video feed with positive-only actions and no way to steer it



- 1 The rail is all positive actions**
Like, Comments, Save, Shorts, Share, Play. No one-tap “not for me”, so the feed learns slowly from skips alone.
- 2 Raw video title, truncated**
“Hasan Raheem - Wishes ft T...” uses the uploader’s title, not clean track metadata, and there’s no “new to you” cue.
- 3 No filters**
I can’t ask for Punjabi only, hip-hop only, or only songs I haven’t heard. It’s one endless stream.
- 4 The video carries little information**
A dark, near-black frame. The visual doesn’t help me judge the song, so I have to listen to each one.

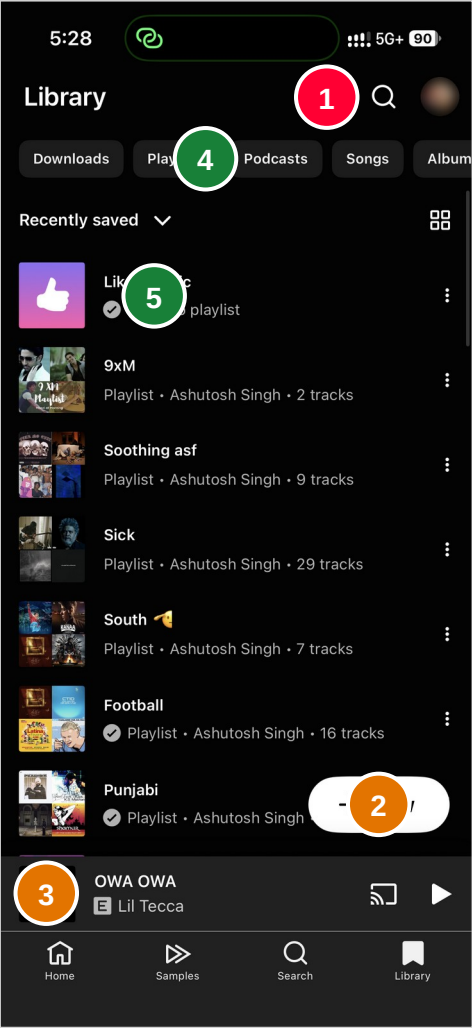
YOUTUBE'S OWN GOAL

“We didn’t build this experience to be a means to an end in itself, but instead to be the appetizer to a whole meal.”

YouTube Blog, Aug 2023

SO WHAT An appetizer with no menu: Samples is great for serendipity but can’t answer “new Punjabi songs I haven’t heard”. As the only discovery tab, it carries a job it wasn’t built for.

Library audit: History hides behind an icon in the Library tab, and the “+ New” button covers content



- 1

History = unlabelled clock in Library
From Home it takes a tab switch plus an icon tap. The Help Center route is 4 levels deep and calls it “watch history”.
- 2

“+ New” button covers content
It hides the Punjabi playlist’s track count, and it doesn’t collapse while scrolling.
- 3

Mini-player lost its artwork
Blank black tile for the now-playing song. A small fault, but it looks broken.
- 4

Clear filter chips
Downloads, Playlists, Podcasts, Songs, Albums: good information scent.
- 5

Pinned “Liked Music” auto playlist
Reliable anchor for saved songs.

Taps to see what I played an hour ago

From Home, today

Library tabHistory icon

2 + tab switch

Help Center route

ProfileSettingsPrivacy & locationManage watch history

4

Proposed

History icon on Home

1

SO WHAT

“What was that song?” is a daily job for heavy listeners. It deserves a one-tap entry on Home, not a detour through Library or Settings.

Heuristic scorecard: user control and efficiency are the weakest areas across all four tabs

Heuristic	Home	Search	Samples	Library	Main evidence
Visibility of system status	2	3	2	2	Unlabelled tile; no new-to-me state; blank mini-player art
Match with the real world	2	3	1	3	“Plays” vs “views”; raw video titles in Samples
User control & freedom	1	3	1	3	Feedback is song-level only; no negative action on the Samples rail
Consistency & standards	2	2	2	2	Same song across modules; FAB overlaps list
Recognition over recall	2	3	2	2	No history on Home; clock icon unlabelled in Library
Flexibility & efficiency	1	2	1	3	No familiar/fresh control; charts not personal; no Samples filters
Aesthetic & minimalist design	2	2	2	2	27-tile Speed dial dominates; keyboard hides browse
Average	1.7	2.6	1.6	2.4	Samples and Home score lowest

1 = major issue 2 = friction 3 = good

Public evidence agrees: paying users want to steer recommendations, and even YouTube is testing fresher picks

CONTROL

“Opened YTM today, and six out of ten recommendations were AI slop.”

Reddit user, quoted by Dexerto · post had 370+ upvotes (PiunikaWeb), Jan 2026

CONTROL

“Clicking ‘I’m not interested’ nor thumbing them down really makes no difference as it only applies to this one specific song.”

Reddit user, quoted by Dexerto, Jan 2026

CHURN RISK

“Google really needs to implement AI filter fast. Otherwise I will cancel my subscription.”

Reddit user, quoted by Dexerto, Jan 2026

UI

A friend switched because “she couldn’t stand how cluttered and clunky YouTube Music looked.” The same author praises its discovery and catalogue.

Android Police, Apr 2025

FRESHNESS

Google tested “Your Daily Discover”, a Home row of new picks labelled “Because you liked X” or “For fans of Y”.

RouteNote / Music Ally, Aug 2025 (test, server-side)

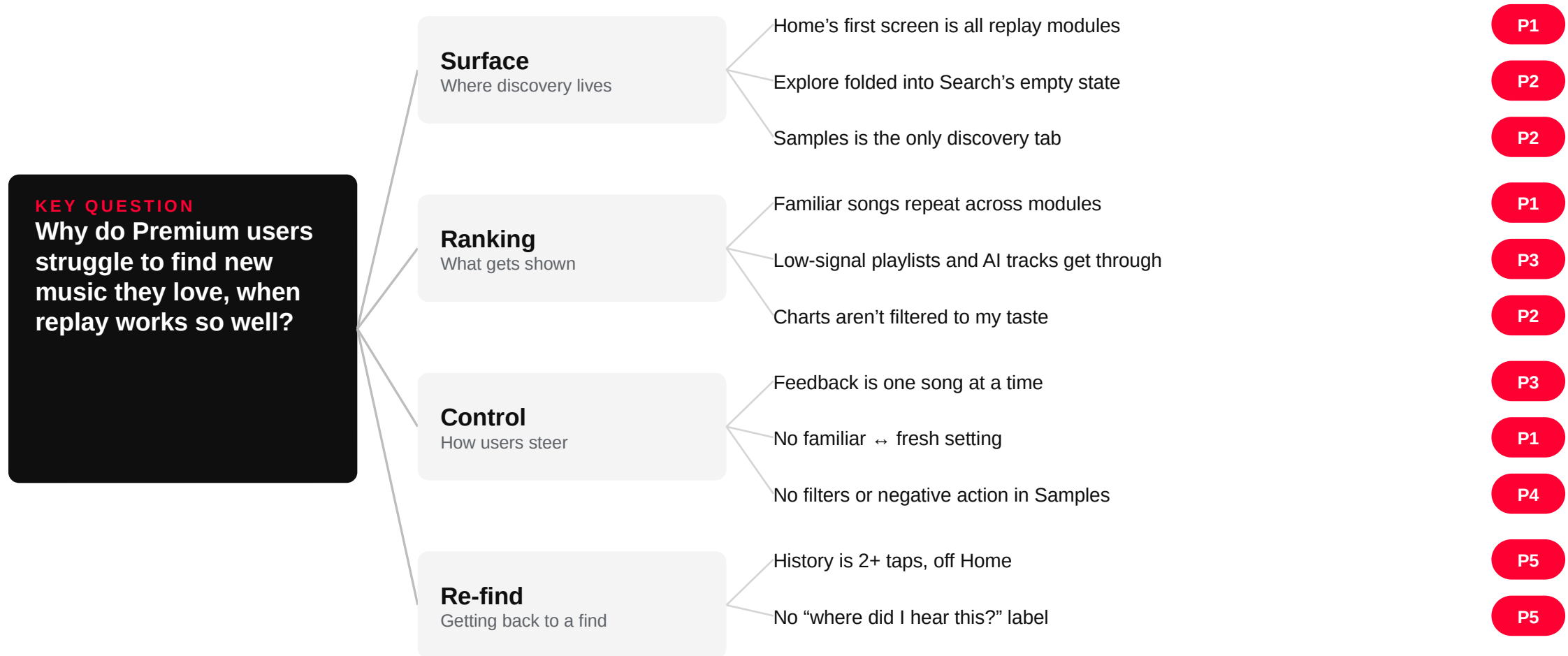
NAVIGATION

Moving Search to the bottom bar removes quick search from the top of the interface: a reachability trade-off.

9to5Google, Aug 2025

SO WHAT Three themes: control (feedback and AI), freshness (YouTube’s own Daily Discover test) and navigation. They match what my screens show.

Root cause: discovery is under-weighted in YouTube Music's layout, ranking and controls



P1 Replay-first Home · P2 No discovery home · P3 No steering · P4 Samples can't be aimed · P5 Re-find friction

P1 · Home optimises for replay: my first screen is 100% on-repeat content, and new-to-me rows come late

Home modules in my account, in scroll order

#	Module	What it shows	Familiar or new?
1	Speed dial	27 tiles “on repeat” (9 per page)	Familiar
2	Quick picks	Mixed; repeats Speed dial items	Mostly familiar
3	New from Karan Aujla	New EP from a followed artist	New
4	Albums for you	Classic albums (2007, 2020)	Canon
5	From your library	My own playlists	Familiar
6	Similar to OLD ENG LIKED	User playlists, 2K–4.1K views	New, low signal
7	Bollywood & Indian	Relevant playlists / EPs	Mixed
8	Mixed for you	Personal mixes (below the fold)	Mixed

Classification is my judgement from one account (n = 1).

Why it matters

+25 pp

more likely to convert Free → Premium: users with more diverse listening (Spotify Research, 2020)

10–20 pp

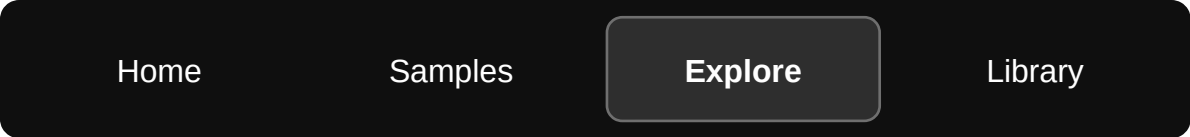
less likely to churn: diverse listeners, controlling for activity level (same study)

The same study found algorithmic listening was less diverse than organic listening. Recommenders narrow taste unless they are designed not to. And YouTube’s own 2025 “Daily Discover” test suggests the team sees the gap too.

HYPOTHESIS Reserving above-the-fold slots for new-to-me songs, and deduplicating modules, raises Weekly New-Favourite Listeners without cutting total listening time.

P2 - Discovery has no home: Explore was folded into Search, leaving Samples as the only discovery tab

Until Jun 2026



Search: top-bar icon

Since Jun 2026

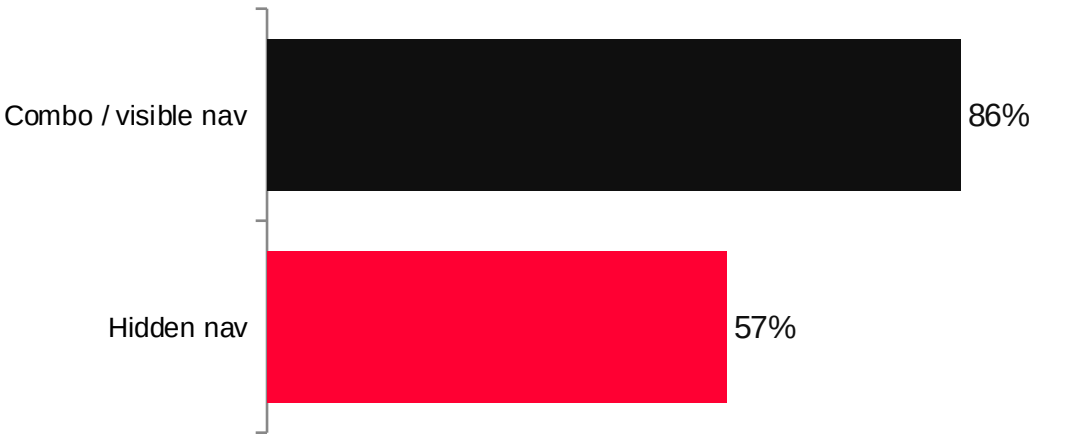


Explore → Search empty state

What each tab is for now

Tab	Job it serves	Discovery role
Home	Replay (Speed dial, Quick picks)	Weak, below the fold
Samples	Lean-back serendipity	Only dedicated tab; no filters
Search	Find a known song	Generic charts in empty state

Evidence: when navigation is hidden, people find it less



Share of mobile sessions in which people used the site navigation (NN/g, 2016). NN/g: hiding navigation “cuts discoverability almost in half”. This is web-based evidence, so treat it as directional for apps.

SO WHAT Discovery went from a tab to the empty state of a utility. Charts and New releases are still there, but hardly anyone will see them, and they aren’t personal when they do.

P3 · Users can't steer: feedback works one song at a time, and AI-generated tracks slip through

Steering controls: what exists vs what users ask for

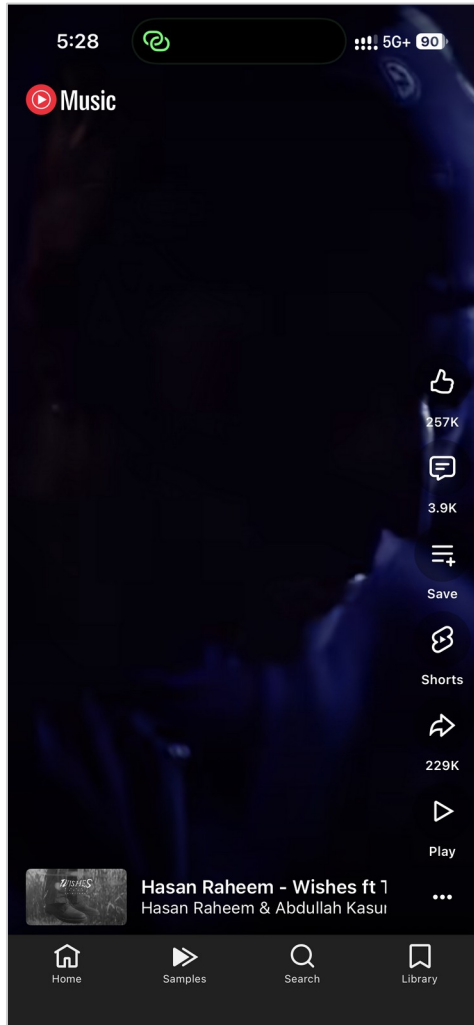
Control	Scope	Today	Evidence
Thumbs down / Not interested	One song	✓	Reported to remove one song only; similar tracks return
Don't recommend this artist	Artist, all surfaces	✗	Users ask to block artists (Dexerto)
Fewer songs like this	Style / cluster	✗	Gap implied by "only this one song" complaints
Reduce AI-generated music	Labelled content	✗	No filter; creator disclosure exists (MediaNama)
Familiar ↔ Fresh mix	Home ranking	✗	Not in the app; YouTube tested Daily Discover
Negative action in Samples	Feed	✗	Not on the rail (Help Center, my screen)

Also observed: "Similar to OLD ENG LIKED" recommends user playlists with 2K–4.1K views and no quality cue. More low-signal input with no user override.

SIGNAL FROM PAYING USERS
"Tapping 'Not interested' or thumbs-down doesn't seem to solve the problem. At best, it removes a single song, but similar AI-generated tracks quickly take its place."
Android Authority, Jan 2026

SO WHAT The cost is trust, not just relevance. When a subscriber can't fix a bad feed, they start thinking about cancelling.

P4 - Samples is built for serendipity, but can't answer “new Punjabi songs I haven't heard yet”



Samples vs the job my persona hires it for

What Samples does well

- Instant 30-second previews: low effort per song
- Full-screen, one-thumb swiping
- One tap to Save, Share, or make a Short
- Now also on artist pages (Jan 2025)

Where it breaks the job

- Can't filter by language, genre or “new to me”
- No one-tap negative signal on the rail
- Hard to re-find a sample later; no “from Samples” trail in History
- Raw uploader titles; nothing shows if a song is already in my library

SO WHAT Samples is the right format and the wrong container. Put it inside a Discover hub as the “Feed” mode, add filters and a “Not for me” action, and it becomes a steerable discovery tool instead of an endless scroll.

P5 · Small frictions add up: re-finding needs a tab switch, and six UI defects wear down polish

Re-find

Today
Home → Library tab → clock icon (unlabelled). The Help Center documents a 4-step Settings route and calls it “watch history”.

Also missing
No “where did I hear this?” source. A song I liked in Samples is hard to trace later.

Proposed
Clock icon on the Home top bar, next to the bell. History rows show their source: “from Samples”, “from Quick picks”.

UI hygiene backlog

Defect (observed)	Screen	Fix	Effort
“+ New” button covers playlist metadata	Library	Shrink to icon on scroll; add bottom padding to the list	S
“Plays” and “views” mixed; “133M vie...” truncated	Home	One metric for songs; drop counts or wrap to 2 lines	S
Speed dial tile with no label or artwork	Home	Always label; fallback artwork for mixes	S
Blank artwork in the mini-player	Library	Cache artwork; show a placeholder while loading	S
“Podcasts” is the first mood chip	Home	Order chips by the user’s listening mix	S
Raw uploader titles in Samples	Samples	Use clean track title and artist metadata	M

SO WHAT One sprint, six fixes. Cheap to ship, and each one makes the product feel more reliable.

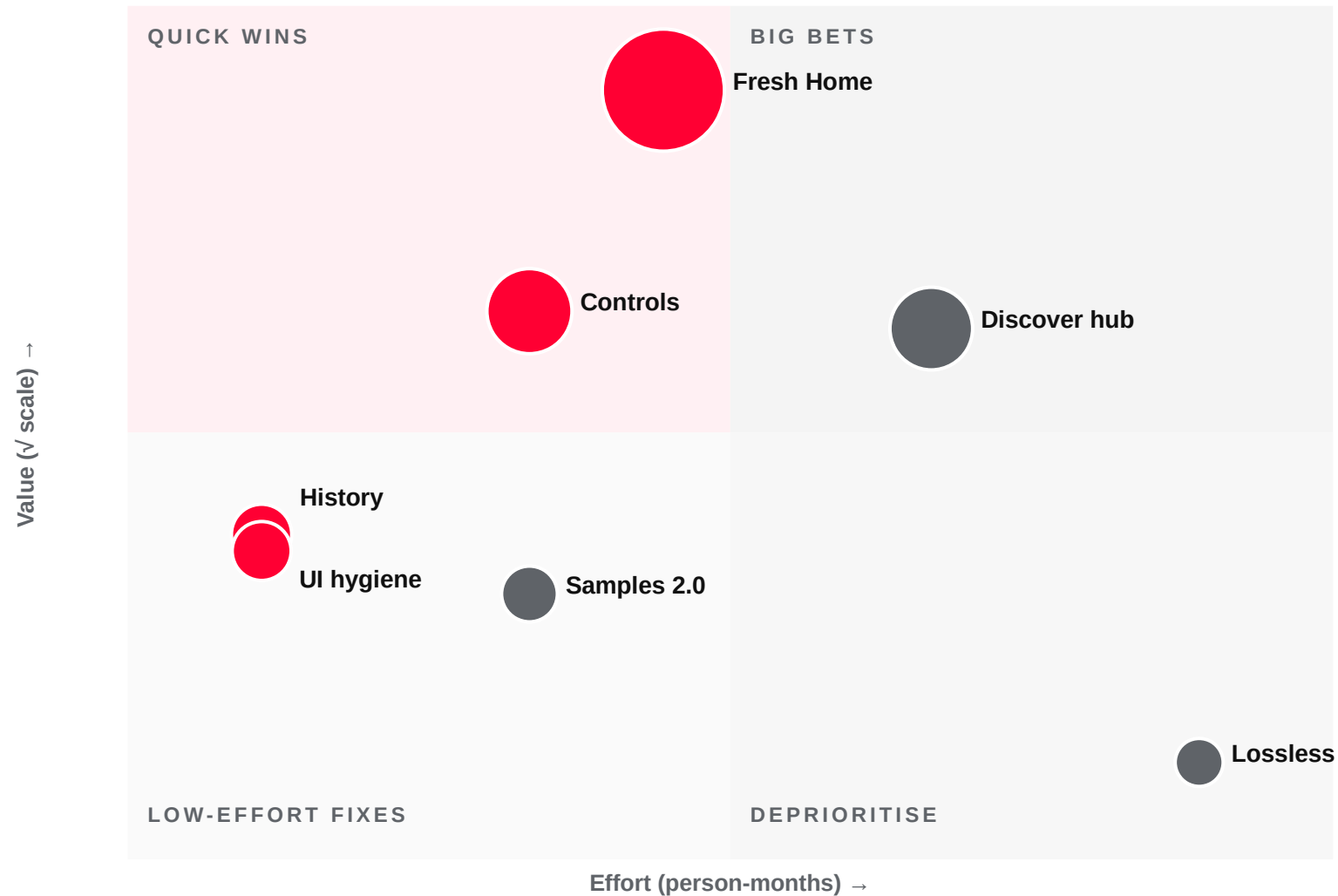
RICE ranks Fresh Home first. History, controls and UI hygiene are cheap wins. The Discover hub is big but uncertain, so we test it

Rank	Initiative	Solves	Reach	Impact	Confidence	Effort	RICE
1	Fresh Home (new-to-me row, dedupe, dial)	P1	90%	2	70%	4 pm	31.5
2	One-tap History + source labels	P5	50%	0.5	90%	1 pm	22.5
3	Steering controls (artist block, fewer like this, less AI)	P3	40%	2	80%	3 pm	21.3
4	UI hygiene sprint	P5	90%	0.25	90%	1 pm	20.3
5	Discover hub (IA change)	P2	60%	2	50%	6 pm	10.0
6	Samples 2.0 (filters, Not for me, New to me)	P4	25%	1	60%	3 pm	5.0
7	Lossless tier (watch-list)	—	5%	1	40%	8 pm	0.3

RICE = Reach × Impact × Confidence ÷ Effort

SO WHAT Ship the cheap wins in weeks 0–6. Test Fresh Home and controls as the core bets. Run the IA change as an experiment. Park lossless until we have data.

Sequencing: quick wins first, two core bets next, and the IA change only behind an experiment

**NOW · 0–6 weeks**

UI hygiene sprint · History on Home · instrument the “new-to-me” flag

NEXT · Quarter 1

Fresh Home A/B · Steering controls A/B · “Not for me” on the Samples rail

LATER · Quarter 2+

Discover hub 3-arm test · Charts for you · Samples 2.0 filters

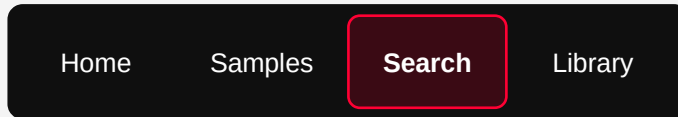
WATCH

Lossless: revisit if Premium churn surveys cite audio quality

Navigation: keep Search in the thumb zone and give discovery its own tab. Option B, tested against A

CURRENT

Shipped Jun 2026



For

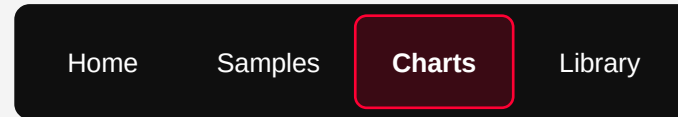
- Search within thumb reach; matches other streaming apps

Against

- Charts and New releases buried in Search
- Samples is the only discovery tab

OPTION A

Search to top bar, add “Charts for you” tab



Top bar: Search · History · Bell

For

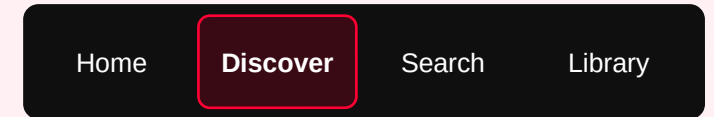
- Personal charts one tap away
- History and Search on Home

Against

- Reverses a reachability change
- Discovery split across two tabs
- Search needs a top bar on every tab

OPTION B · RECOMMENDED

Discover hub replaces Samples



Discover = Feed · Charts for you · New releases

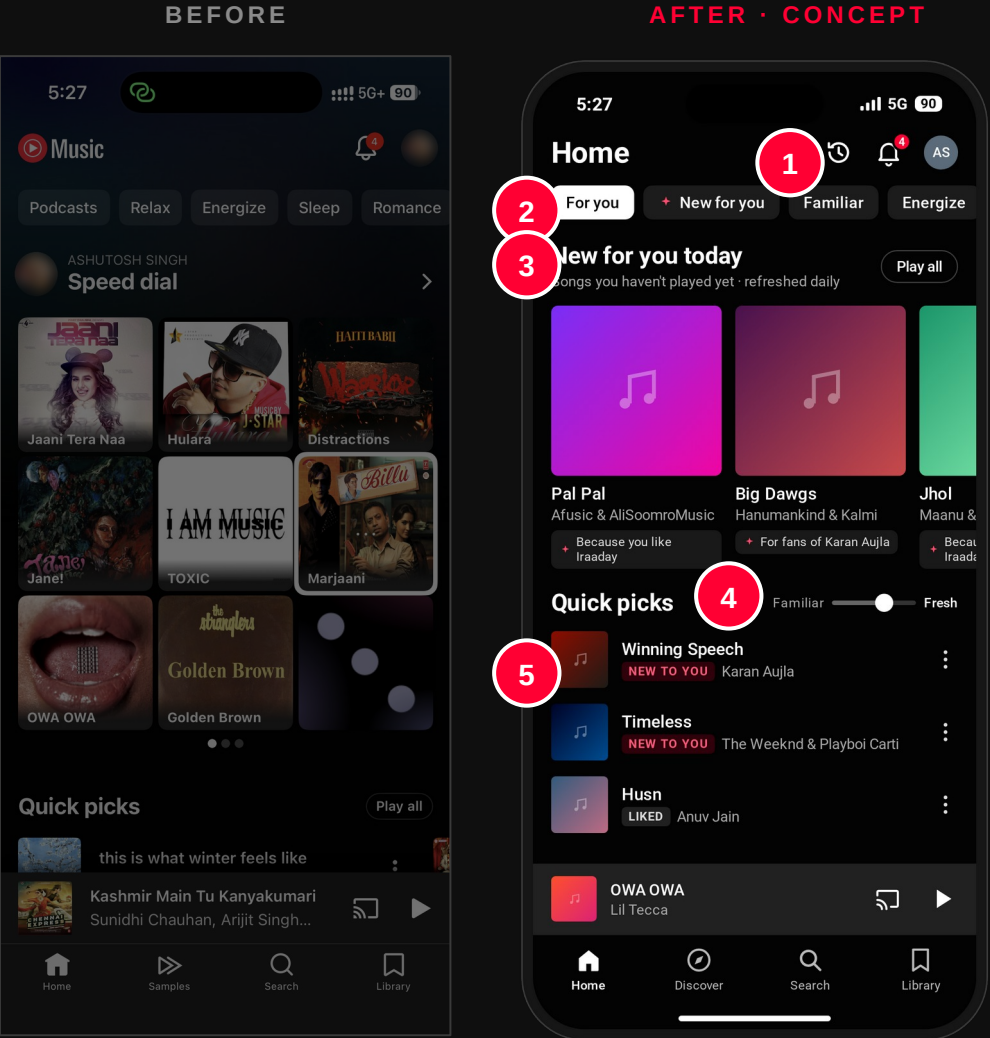
For

- One home for all discovery
- Keeps Search reachable
- Samples becomes a mode, not a silo

Against

- Samples loses its own tab: watch Shorts/Samples time
- Busier tab to design

Bet 1 · Fresh Home: guarantee new-to-me music above the fold, remove duplicates, and let users set the mix



- 1

History on the top bar
One tap from Home to “what was that song?” **P5**
- 2

Chips ordered by my listening
“New for you” added; Podcasts moves to the end for a music-first user. **P1**
- 3

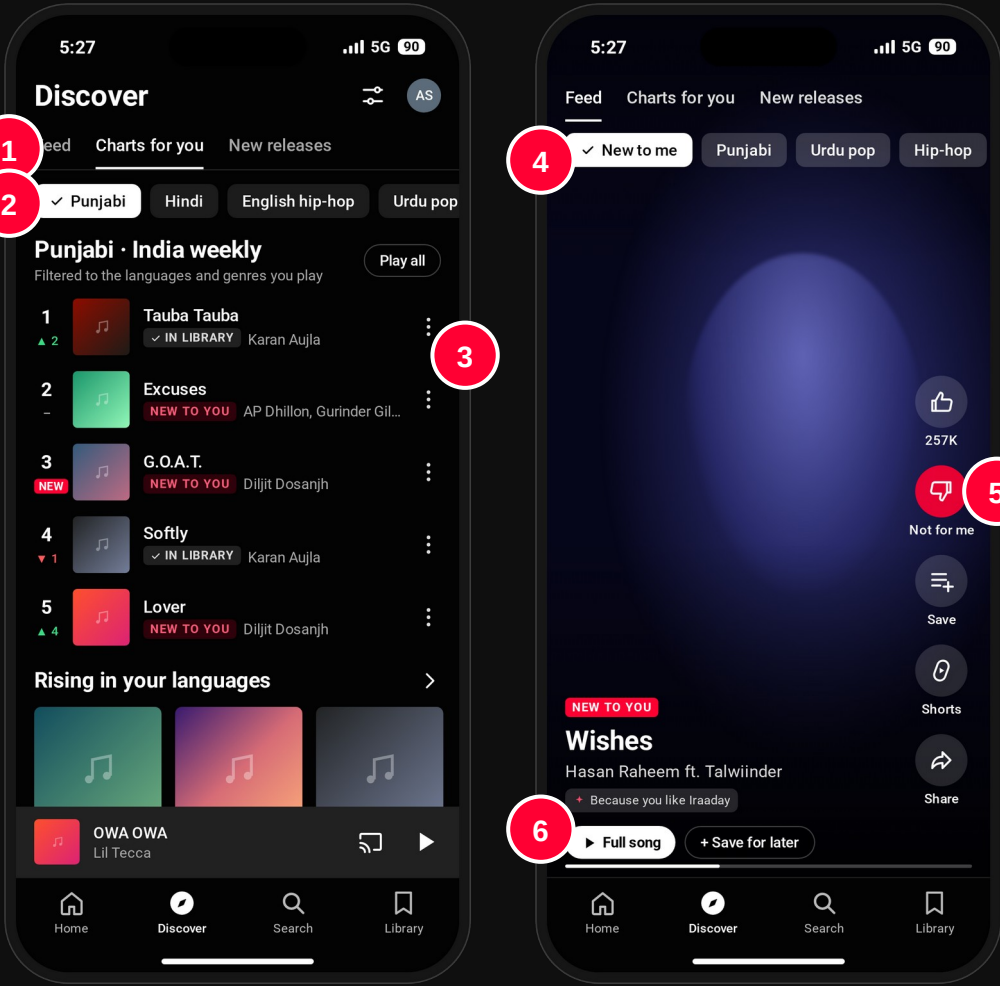
“New for you today”
Songs I’ve never played, with a reason label (“Because you like Iraaday”). Refreshed daily. **P1**
- 4

Familiar ↔ Fresh dial
A visible control for the explore/exploit balance. Default is set per user. **P3**
- 5

Dedupe + honest tags
No song appears twice above the fold. “New to you” and “Liked” tags show why each song is here. **P1**

Bet 2 · Discover hub: one tab for discovery, with personal charts, new releases and a steerable Samples feed

DISCOVER · CHARTS FOR YOU DISCOVER · FEED (SAMPLES 2.0)



- 1 Three modes, one tab
Feed · Charts for you · New releases. Replaces the Samples tab (Option B). P2
- 2 Taste filters
Languages and genres pre-selected from listening; editable in one tap. P2
- 3 In library vs New to you
Every chart row shows whether I already know it. P1
- 4 “New to me” filter in the feed
Plus language and genre chips. Samples becomes aimable. P4
- 5 One-tap “Not for me”
A negative signal on the rail, next to Like. P4
- 6 Clean title + Save for later
Canonical track metadata; a later-queue for finds. P5

Bets 3 & 4 · Put users in control: artist-level feedback, a “less AI” setting, and one-tap History that shows where you heard it

STEERING SHEET (LONG-PRESS)

5:27 5G 90

Home

Quick picks

Winning Speech

Karan Aujla

Untitled Lo-fi 12

Lumen Vale

Husn

Anuv Jain

Untitled Lo-fi 12

AI-GENERATED · DISCLOSED

Lumen Vale

WHY ISN'T THIS FOR YOU?

1

Not interested in this song

2

Don't recommend Lumen Vale

Blocks the artist across Home, mixes and radio

2

Fewer songs like this

Tunes down this style everywhere

3

Report unlabelled AI music

YOUR RECOMMENDATION MIX

Familiar

Fresh

4

Show less AI-generated music

Uses creator disclosure labels

HISTORY (FROM HOME)

5:27 5G 90

< History

🔍

All

Songs

Albums

Playlists

Podcasts

5

PICK UP WHERE YOU LEFT OFF

Punjabi

Your playlist · stopped at track 7

▶

Today

OWA OWA

Lil Tecca

5:26 PM · FROM SPEED DIAL

Kashmir Main Tu Kanyakumari

Sunidhi Chauhan, Arijit Singh...

5:18 PM · FROM SEARCH

Wishes

Hasan Raheem ft. Talwiinder

4:52 PM · FROM SAMPLES

Yesterday

Golden Brown

The Stranglers

11:40 PM · FROM QUICK PICKS

Iraadaya

Abdul Hannan & Rovalio

11:36 PM · FROM QUICK PICKS

Straight Up

Karan Aujla & Mxrci

10:02 PM · FROM NEW FROM KARAN AUJLA

Home

Discover

Search

Library

1

Artist-level block

Applies across Home, mixes and radio. Fixes the “one song at a time” complaint. P3

2

“Fewer songs like this”

Tunes down a style cluster, not just one track. P3

3

Recommendation mix, in one place

The same Familiar ↔ Fresh dial as on Home. P1

4

“Show less AI-generated music”

Uses creator disclosure; plus “Report unlabelled AI music” to catch what disclosure misses. P3

5

Pick up where you left off

Resume the last playlist or queue in one tap. P5

6

Source labels

“From Samples”, “From Quick picks”: answers “where did I hear this?” P5

Success metrics: one north star for discovery, protected by guardrails on listening, search and churn

NORTH STAR

Weekly New-Favourite Listeners

% of weekly active users who, in a given week, save a song they had never played before, or play it again on a later day.

Why this metric
It captures discovery that sticks, not just exposure. It maps to the listening-diversity link with retention (Spotify Research, 2020). And it can't be gamed by replay.

Input metrics (what the team moves)

Stage	Metric	Moved by
Exposure	Share of above-the-fold Home impressions that are new to the user	Bet 1
Exposure	Discover tab reach (% of WAU opening it weekly)	Bet 2
Engagement	New-to-me play-through rate (> 30 s)	Bets 1, 2
Engagement	Feed → full-song rate	Bet 2
Control	Repeat-offender rate: blocked artist or AI track resurfacing (target ≈ 0)	Bet 3
Re-find	History opens per WAU; plays that start from History	Bet 4

Guardrails (must not regress)

Listening minutes per WAU

Home skip rate within 30 s

Search success (search → play within 60 s)

Premium voluntary churn and cancel reasons

Samples / Shorts minutes

Home load time and crash-free sessions

Experiment plan: four tests, each with a pre-set decision rule, and a long-term holdout for the navigation change

Test	Design	Primary metric	Guardrails	Duration	Ship if...
E1 · Fresh Home	User-level A/B, Premium users in India	Weekly New-Favourite Listeners	Minutes / WAU; 30 s skip rate	4 weeks (covers weekly cycles and novelty)	North star up (significant) and minutes non-inferior
E2 · Steering controls	A/B; sheet + artist block + less-AI setting	Repeat-offender rate; North star	Minutes; share of feedback taps	3 weeks	Repeat-offender rate down, no minutes loss
E3 · Navigation	3-arm: Current vs Option A vs Option B	North star; Discover reach	Search success; Samples/Shorts minutes	6 weeks + 5% holdout for 3 months	Best arm wins on North star with search non-inferior
E4 · History entry	A/B; clock icon on Home + source labels	History opens; plays started from History	Home top-bar tap confusion (bell taps)	2 weeks	Opens up; no drop in notification engagement

Pre-register

Metrics, MDE and decision rules are written before launch

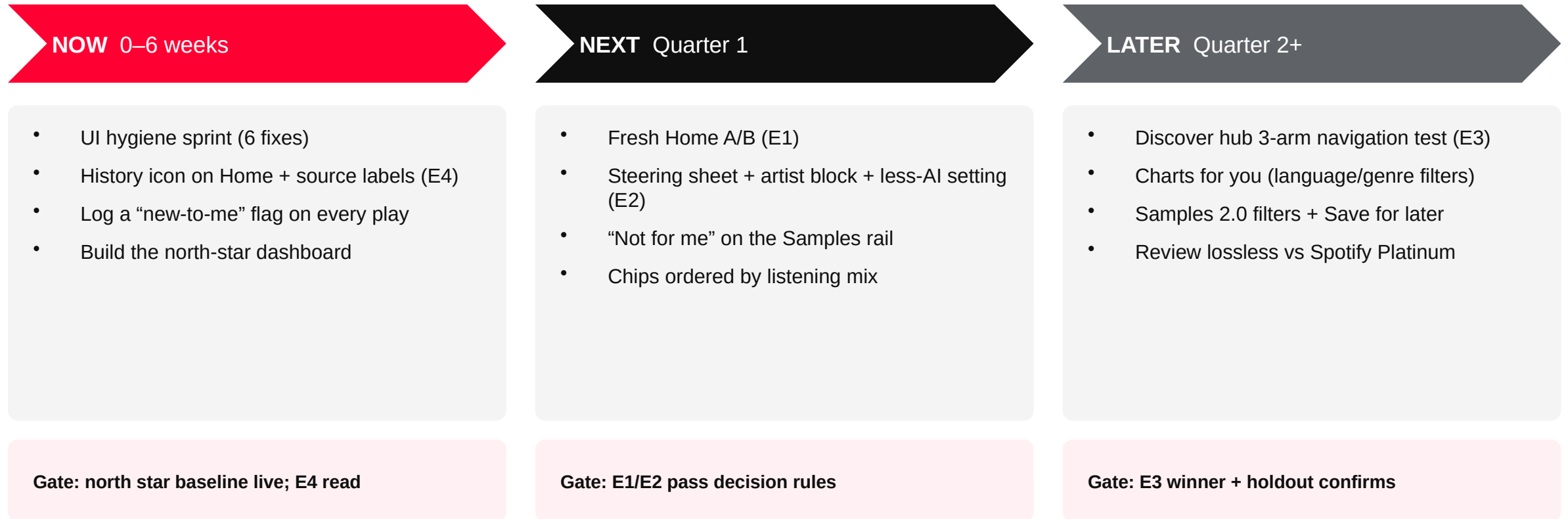
Segment readouts

Personas A / B / C, languages, new vs tenured users

Qualitative loop

8–10 interviews per test arm to explain the “why”

Roadmap: earn trust with quick wins, prove the core bets, then change navigation only on evidence



SO WHAT Dependencies: data science to log the “new-to-me” flag and the north star; Trust & Safety for AI-disclosure labels; label partnerships before shipping Charts for you.

Risks and trade-offs I would put in front of leadership

Risk	Why it could happen	Likelihood	Mitigation
Freshness lowers listening time	Unfamiliar songs get skipped more than favourites	Med	Conservative dial default; minutes guardrail; per-persona defaults
Navigation change breaks habits	Muscle memory; the Samples tab has its own fans	High	3-arm test, 3-month holdout, Search stays in the bottom bar (B)
“Less AI” over-promises	Only as good as creator disclosure	High	Honest naming; artist block + report flow; no “AI-free” claim
Personal charts dilute credibility	Labels and artists value official chart positions	Low	Filter, don’t re-rank; “Charts for you” naming; official charts one tap away
Cold start for new users	No history means no “new to me” signal	Med	Language picker at onboarding; fall back to regional charts
Samples / Shorts minutes drop	Feed becomes one of three modes	Med	Feed is the default Discover mode; minutes guardrail

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